English Test and Interview Preparation Plan

Version 1.0, 5 November 2026

1. Which test does each shortlisted programme accept?

Programme	IELTS Academic	TOEFL iBT	PTE Academic	Duolingo (DET)	Waiver for you?	Class
CMU-Africa MSIT	✅ 6.5 (recommended)	✅ 81 (French page: 87)	**✗ not listed**	✅ 120	No	E2
CYBERSURE (Erasmus Mundus)	✅ **6.5, Writing ≥ 6.0**	✅ 92/W22 (old scale) or 4.5 per section	**✗ not listed**	**✗ not listed**	No (Ethiopia not exempt)	E2
Sweden (university admissions.se / SI)	not needed	not needed	not needed	not needed	✅ **Ethiopian bachelor's meets English 6**	E2
University of Manitoba	✅ 6.5	⏳	⏳	⏳	No	E2 (IELTS only)
Stipendium Hungaricum	✅ B2 (e.g. 5.5–6.0, per programme)	✅ (e.g. 72 at BME)	⏳	⏳	Per programme	E2 (partial)
CSC China	per university	per university	⏳	⏳	Some accept a medium-of-instruction letter (⏳)	E2
GKS Korea	optional (adds points)	optional	—	—	n/a	E2
SE4GD	⏳	⏳	⏳	⏳	⏳	—
Chevening 2028 (UK)	per university	per university	per university	DET is **not** accepted for UK	—	E3

Programme	IELTS Academic	TOEFL iBT	PTE Academic	Duolingo (DET)	Waiver for you?	Class
				visas		

Conclusion: IELTS Academic is the only test accepted by every programme on your list that needs a test. The DET is useful **only for CMU-Africa**, and its fee is covered if you apply early. **PTE is not accepted by your two highest-priority programmes that need a test, so skip it.** TOEFL works as an alternative to IELTS but adds nothing.

2. Cost and availability in Ethiopia

All prices below are E3 estimates and must be confirmed with the provider.

Test	Where	Approximate cost	Notes
IELTS Academic	British Council centres: Addis Ababa University and Hawassa University (E2 ielts.org)	Not confirmed; one listing showed about ETB 22,000 for 2025 dates (E3). **Ask the centre for the birr price.**	Computer-delivered results usually arrive faster; confirm the turnaround locally
TOEFL iBT	Addis Ababa centres (E3)	about USD 210–225 (E3)	Paid in USD
PTE Academic	⏳ Addis Ababa centre not confirmed	about USD 245–265 (E3)	Not needed
DET	Online at home	about USD 59–70 (E3); **free for CMU-Africa early applicants** (E2)	Needs a quiet room, webcam and stable internet

3. Plan: two tests, in this order

1. **DET** in the first half of December, through CMU-Africa's covered-fee route after you submit by 15 Dec. Target **≥ 120**.
2. **IELTS Academic**, booked by **20 Nov** for a test **in the first half of December**.
   - Target overall **7.0** with **no band below 6.5**, which gives a margin over CYBERSURE's 6.5 / W6.0 and Manitoba's 6.5.
   - Needed for CYBERSURE (if eligible), Manitoba, Hungary and CSC.

4. Five-week schedule (9 Nov – 13 Dec 2026), about 90 minutes a day on work days and 3 hours on Saturday

Your self-rated weakest skill is **speaking (B1)**, so it gets the most time.

Week	Daily (Mon–Fri, 90 min)	Saturday (3 h)	Target by end of week
1 (9–15 Nov)	20 min listening (lectures/podcasts, note-taking) · 20 min reading (1 timed passage) · 20 min writing (one Task 2 paragraph) · **30 min speaking** (record 3 × 2-minute answers on work topics)	**Diagnostic:** full IELTS practice test plus a DET practice test	Know your baseline band per skill
2 (16–22 Nov)	Same; add a 15-word/day academic and tech vocabulary log	Task 1 (graphs/processes) + Task 2 under time	Writing: clear 4-paragraph essays in 40 minutes
3 (23–29 Nov)	Speaking Part 2 cue cards daily; reading True/False/Not Given practice	Full timed mock #2	+0.5 band on the weakest skill
4 (30 Nov – 6 Dec)	Error-log review; DET-specific tasks (read-aloud, write-about-photo)	DET practice + full IELTS mock #3	DET practice ≥ 120
5 (7–13 Dec)	Light review; sleep and logistics	**Real tests**	DET ≥ 120; IELTS 7.0

Free official materials (sites not reachable from this session; open them yourself):

- ielts.org / British Council "Prepare" sample tests
- Duolingo English Test practice test (englishtest.duolingo.com)

Assessment: after each mock, log the scores in the tracker's *Interview Preparation* sheet.

5. Interview programme

5.1 Format

From week 3, we run **one mock interview a week** in this session:

- one question at a time
- you type or dictate your answer
- I correct grammar, vocabulary, clarity, structure, relevance and confidence markers, then give one improved version **built only from your verified facts**

5.2 Answer method

PEER: Point → Example → Effect → Reflection. 60–90 seconds per answer.

5.3 Core question bank

A. GPA and academic weaknesses (hardest; prepare first)

1. Your GPA is 2.62. Why should we admit you?
2. Why did you fail Probability & Statistics and Discrete Mathematics on the first attempt?
3. Our programme is mathematically demanding. How will you cope?
4. What does your extension-programme study mode mean?
5. Which course did you find hardest, and what did you learn from it?
6. Tell us about your final-year project.

Model answer framework for Q1 (facts verified; delivery is yours):

> "My cumulative GPA is 2.62, and I won't hide that my first years were weak, especially in mathematics. But the trend matters: my final-year semester averages were 3.05 and 3.35, and my best grades were in Compiler Design, Advanced Programming, Complexity Theory and my final-year project, all A–. Since graduating I have worked [⏳ N] years on production payment infrastructure, which has given me a practical foundation that many graduates don't have. I know mathematics is where I must work hardest, and I'm [⏳ real preparation step]."

B. Professional experience (answers wait for the HR-confirmed facts)

7. Walk us through your current role.
8. Describe a production incident you handled. What was the root cause?
9. How does your CI/CD pipeline work, step by step?
10. What did you automate with Ansible, and why?
11. How do you monitor services? What alert would wake you at 3 a.m.?
12. How do you secure access to production systems?
13. Explain how a POS payment travels from the terminal to the bank. *(Answer only to the depth you actually know.)*
14. You worked at SantimPay and Kifiya at the same time. How did that work? ***(Must match the HR letters exactly.)***
15. What is the biggest mistake you have made at work?

C. Leadership

16. Describe a time you led people without formal authority.
17. Tell us about a conflict in a team and how it was resolved.
18. How did you help someone else learn a skill?
19. What does leadership mean in a technical team?
20. Describe a decision you made with incomplete information.

D. Motivation and fit

21. Why this programme? Why this university or country?
22. Why now, after [⏳ N] years of work?
23. What will you do if you don't receive the scholarship?
24. What will you contribute to your classmates?

E. Ethiopia, Africa and the future

25. How will you use this degree in Ethiopia?
26. What is the biggest technology challenge in Ethiopian digital payments?
27. Where do you see yourself 5 and 10 years after graduating?
28. How will you give back to your community? *(Real commitments only.)*
29. Would you return to Ethiopia? Why? *(Return obligations: Mastercard Foundation, Chevening, Fulbright J-1.)*
30. What would you change about Ethiopia's tech ecosystem?

F. Technical and academic (CS fundamentals; revise these)

31. Explain CAP theorem trade-offs in a payment system.
32. What happens when you type a URL into a browser?
33. Process vs thread; container vs virtual machine.
34. How does TLS establish a secure connection?
35. What is the principle of least privilege? Give an example from your work.
36. How does Kubernetes restart a failed pod?
37. Explain public-key cryptography to a non-expert.
38. What is idempotency, and why does it matter in Ansible and in payments?
39. Big-O of common operations on a hash map vs a balanced tree.
40. How would you design a highly available service on two datacentres?

The full bank (50 scholarship, 30 technical, 20 leadership, 20 experience questions) with model answers will be completed **after** the experience facts are verified, because answers cannot be modelled on unconfirmed roles.